

project.org

STUDENT HANDOUT

RED LEVEL
GO DEEPER

The Sound of Harlem

Grades 5–8 · Music

ADMIT ONE

NAME _____ DATE _____ CLASS _____

Critical frame: Duke Ellington said: "Jazz is not just music — it is a way of life, a way of feeling, a way of thinking." Analyze one recording's full structural architecture, then compose an original phrase within the blues framework, and write a critical essay connecting jazz structure to its cultural and historical context.

ACTIVITY 1

Full structural analysis: analyze one recording in depth

Recording selected:

ELEMENT	WHAT YOU HEAR	WHAT IT DOES — FUNCTION OR EFFECT
Harmonic structure (12-bar / other)		
Syncopation (where / how)		
Call-and-response (which instruments)		
Improvisation (who / when)		
Rhythm section role		
Dynamics / expression		

What is the single most striking musical choice in this recording? Why?

ACTIVITY 2

Composition task: write a 4-bar melody over the blues

Using the 12-bar blues framework (bars 1–4 are chord I), write an original 4-bar melody. Use standard notation, solfège, or letter names for each beat. Your melody must include at least one **syncopated note** (off-beat accent) and one **"blue note"** (flattened 3rd or 7th).

> Key of C — Bars 1–4 all use chord C (I). Time signature: 4/4

BAR 1 — C

Beat 1	+	Beat 2	+	Beat 3	+	Beat 4	+

BAR 2 — C

Beat 1	+	Beat 2	+	Beat 3	+	Beat 4	+

BAR 3 — C

Beat 1	+	Beat 2	+	Beat 3	+	Beat 4	+

BAR 4 — C

Beat 1	+	Beat 2	+	Beat 3	+	Beat 4	+

Where did you place your syncopated note? _____ **Bar** _____ **Beat** _____

What blue note did you use? _____ **What effect does it create?** _____

ACTIVITY 3

Critical essay

Duke Ellington said jazz is "a way of life, a way of feeling, a way of thinking." Using your structural analysis and what you know about the Harlem Renaissance, write 4–5 sentences arguing: **what did jazz make possible for Black Americans in the 1920s that other art forms could not?**

MINI MUSEUM DEEP DIVE

In the **Jazz Lab**, isolate the rhythm section (bass, drums, piano). Listen to how the music changes without it. What does the rhythm section actually do — is it accompaniment, or something more fundamental? How does your answer connect to the African rhythmic traditions that gave jazz its foundation?

minimuseumproject.org/exhibitions/harlem-renaissance